

Ours Republicans approved 12 times larger tax breaks for "people making over 350 grand" than for "the average middle-class person. The state Assembly's Democratic leader, veteran Rep. Peter Barca of Kenosha, looked drained and sounded down when asked to explain his party's poor showing in the Nov. 4, 2014 elections. And it's no wonder: Democrats failed to recapture either legislative chamber and in the Assembly will face the largest Republican majority since Barca was a toddler in the mid-1950s. Here's how Barca responded when Wisconsin Public Television's Frederica Freyberg put the question to him Nov. 7, 2014: "We've got to communicate differently with the middle class, because there's no question the middle class is much stronger with the Democratic Party. Even in our state, 12 times the tax breaks were for people making over 350 grand than the average middle-class person. We've got to go back to the drawing board." That claim about income tax cuts drew our attention. Democratic candidates around the state, including Mary Burke at the top of the ticket, pounded their GOP opponents over income-tax breaks approved by the Republican-led Legislature and Gov. Scott Walker. They argued the breaks were too tilted to the higher income level. Republicans countered that separate tax cuts Walker signed benefitted earners at all levels. Walker's second budget, for 2013-2015, lowered income tax rates (while reducing the number of tax brackets from five to four). And later, in 2014, Walker signed legislation that dropped the lowest rate again (from 4.4 percent to 4 percent). Asked to back up the claim, Barca spokeswoman Laura Smith pointed us to a June 2013 report by the Legislative Fiscal Bureau, the state's nonpartisan budget scorekeeper. That report broke down the effect across income groups of the first income tax cuts -- the ones approved in 2013 -- in raw dollar terms. Smith said his mention of the "average middle class person" referred to the median household income in Wisconsin. That was \$52,627 as of the most recent U.S. Census five-year average. The Fiscal Bureau report shows that in the \$50,000 to \$60,000 income range, the average tax savings for 2014 was estimated at \$112. At the level of \$300,000 and above, where Barca's example of "350 grand" falls, the savings were estimated at \$1,

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